

Echoes of Sorrow

Game Proposal — TGC GameJam 2026 (Comic × Twist × Light) — Team Indiesigners

Name	Email	IndieConnect ID
Vansh Jaiswal	vansh.jaiswal@students.iiit.ac.in	groot-ji
Garv Singh	garv.singh@research.iiit.ac.in	Gravity006
Nav Singhal	nav.singhal@students.iiit.ac.in	boredcat
Arya Pandey	arya.pandey@students.iiit.ac.in	arya
Bhumi Chaudhari	bhumi.chaudhari@research.iiit.ac.in	bhumi

High Level Design

Concept Statement

You are a young ghostbuster who arrives in a village full of ghosts that can't move on. The game is told as you telling the story of your own life, like a comic you're narrating. You enter the ghosts' memories, and at each important moment, you make a call: bring it into the **Light** and show them what actually happened, or leave it in the **Dark** and let them keep the version that hurts less. Every choice you make changes the memories of other ghosts in the village. And slowly, you find out the truth: you are the reason they're stuck. The person trying to fix everyone is the one who messed them up.

Genre

Narrative, Mystery, Interactive Comic, Choice-based

Unique Selling Points

- **Connected memories.** A choice in one ghost's memory can cause Light or Dark in someone else's, so you are never just solving one person's story.
- **No right answer.** Telling the truth can help one person and hurt another. There are only consequences.
- **The whole game is a comic.** Memories are pages, key moments are panels, and the interface is speech bubbles and sound effects.
- **The twist.** You are the narrator, the hero, and the problem. The story you're telling about yourself isn't the whole truth.

Product Design

Player Experience and POV

The player plays as a young ghostbuster who has just arrived in the village. The whole game is framed as the ghostbuster telling us their life story, so the narration boxes on every page are in their voice. Every ghost's memory comes to you like a case on your desk, kind of like Papers, Please. You make small decisions without knowing everything, and the consequences show up later, in someone else's life. We want the player to stop and actually think before each call, and to feel the weight of it when they see what it did to someone they weren't even looking at.

Visual Style

The game is presented as an interactive comic, with panels, speech bubbles, big sound effects like BAM! and CRASH!, and exaggerated expressions. Memory panels start grey. Choosing Light floods a panel with colour, and choosing Dark inks it over, so the page itself shows what you've decided. Flashbacks are overlapping panels instead of expensive cutscenes.

Game World Fiction

The ghostbuster comes to a small village where the dead can't move on because of stories they never finished. The player enters their memories, called mindspaces, to find out what happened. At first it looks like something dark is corrupting the ghosts' memories, and the ghostbuster is the one who's come to fix it. But memories are not the whole truth: different people remember the same event differently, and the same unexplained figure keeps showing up in all of them. By the end, the player realises that figure is the ghostbuster. The darkness in the village isn't some outside entity. It's you, and what you did to these people, which the story you've been telling has been leaving out.

How the Themes Fit

- **Comic:** the game's whole presentation and interface. Pages, panels, bubbles and sound effects are what you play with.
- **Light:** the core choice. Light means understanding and truth, Dark means denial and comfort. Neither is simply good or evil.

- **Twist:** memories contradict each other, choices ripple in unexpected directions, and the ghostbuster telling the story turns out to be the one causing the problem.

Detailed and Game Systems Design

Core Loop

1. **Arrive in the village.** The ghostbuster starts telling their story: who they are, and why they've come here.
2. **Meet a ghost.** In the village, you talk to a ghost and hear their side of what happened. Their speech bubbles are cracked and partly blacked out, because they're still in denial.
3. **Enter the mindspace.** You step into their memory, shown as one comic page. Most of it is grey and unclear.
4. **Find fragments.** You click around the page to find memory fragments, usually hidden behind sound effects like SLAM! or CRASH! Each fragment shows you a little more of what really happened.
5. **Make the calls.** At each key moment, you choose Light or Dark. The panel fills with colour or gets inked over.
6. **Return to the village.** A comic page shows how your choices changed other ghosts' memories, and the casebook updates. When you visit the next ghost, some of their moments may already be decided.
7. **Final page.** All the memories come together, and you find out you're the one who's been messing them up.

Objectives and Progression

In the short term, the player's goal is to decide every key moment in a ghost's memory so that the ghost can move on. In the long term, it's to help all the ghosts, understand how their stories connect, and find out what really happened in this village. A ghost moves on once all their moments are decided, and the mix of Light and Dark decides how they leave: at peace, bitter, or not at all.

Game Systems

Memory Connections. Each key moment is undecided, Light or Dark. Moments are linked to moments in other ghosts' memories in two ways. With an **echo** link, the linked memory goes the same way as your choice. With a **shadow** link, it goes the opposite way. To keep it simple and doable in 100 hours, a choice only affects memories directly linked to it (no chain reactions), moments you've already decided never change, the effects only show up when you return to the village, and the order you visit ghosts in matters.

The Casebook. A pinboard the ghostbuster keeps that holds every panel you've seen, with threads between the ones that are linked. Links only appear once you've triggered them, so the player slowly maps out how everyone is connected.

Example

A sister, a brother, and their mother. In the sister's memory, you show her that she was the one who told her brother to leave. That's **Light**. This **echoes** into the brother's memory of "she wanted me gone", which also turns **Light**: he has been remembering it wrong for years. It also **shadows** the mother's memory of staying quiet that night, which turns **Dark**: she knew the whole time, and now everyone does. One honest choice helped two people and hurt the third. That's the feeling we want.

Key Visuals

- **Memory pages:** grey panels that fill with colour or get inked over as you decide.
- **The silhouette:** every ghost's memory has one unexplained figure in the background. On the final page, the light comes up and it's the ghostbuster.
- **The narration boxes:** the ghostbuster's version of events, in their own words. On the final page, the boxes and the panels stop matching.

Scope and Proof of Concept

The full jam build is 1 small village hub, 3 ghosts with 3 key moments each, 1 comic page per ghost, and 1 final page that connects everything, for roughly 10–15 minutes of play. No combat, no open world, no voice acting and no full cutscenes.

Before building the whole story, we prove one connection feels good. We make two ghosts, the sister and the brother, with one page and 3 key moments each, linked by one echo and one shadow. The player goes through the sister first, returns to the village to see what changed, then enters the brother's memory and finds some moments already decided. It works if playtesters react to the changes, go back to figure out why something changed, and want to replay to try the other choice.

Inspiration: Papers, Please — not the setting, just the feeling of making small decisions without knowing everything and seeing the consequences later.